TERMS OF ADMISSION

Written by

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Address
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INT. LIVING ROOM - EARLY EVENING

A knock at the door reveals the warm, intricately decorated interior of the Feldman's living room. MRS. FELDMAN (Age 51) hurriedly weaves her way through chattering friends and family, laughing as she does so to keep the 'ambiance' of her holiday party light and as planned.

As she makes her way to the kitchen, bits of conversation floats by. Dale, a football loving corporate bureaucrat, boasts to a group of middle aged office-y types about his trip to the Galapagos, Aunt Carol and Aunt Marlene snicker in the corner over the recent neighborhood scandal, and Bob Mintz the dentist cracks jokes to a less than amused Diane Hale, the recently divorced law attorney.

In the kitchen, Mrs. Feldman neurotically fixes the collar of her oldest son, SAMUEL (18) while her daughter JULIA (13) eats crackers and cheese from what was supposed to be the appetizer platter for guests.

MRS. FELDMAN
"Now remember to say hello to the Adlers, your father has been working very hard on that deal. It took me ages to get that insufferable woman to RSVP - you'd think I was inviting the Pope."

SAMUEL
(Trying to get his mother's hands off his shirt) "Yeah okay sure mom..."

MRS. FELDMAN
(Noticing a stain on Samuel's shirt) "I told you not to eat anything before people arrived! Go change..."

Samuel walks off, pulling at his re-adjusted collar. Remembering something he turns back.

SAMUEL
Oh mom, do you know if the Kellers are coming?

MRS. FELDMAN
Samuel no I don't, last I heard they were volunteering somewhere dreadful.
(MORE)

MRS. FELDMAN (CONT'D)
Julia, honey, why don't you go say hello to Grammy, I know she has been wanting to hear about your recent school election.

CUT TO:

INT. LIVING ROOM - EVENING

Samuel, now in a different suffocatingly thick sweater, walks into the main living room - tastefully decorated with dark woods and glass, not exactly a family friendly design. As he enters, a subtle hush quiets the room as some flick their eyes towards him.

Samuel take a step forward, running into the shoulder of a nearby man, turning around, he is met with the smiling faces of MR & MRS KELLER.

SAMUEL
"Mr. Keller, Mrs. Keller what a surprise! I didn't think you were going to make it. How are you?"

MR. KELLER
"Quite well! How about you Sam, last we talked you were quite taken with political theory - did you happen to get around to that lecture I recommended?

SAMUEL
Yes sir, one of the best I've seen.

MRS. KELLER
Well if you are ever interested, I am sure you could sit in on one of John's lectures.

Samuel smiles and nods, Mr. Keller, noticing a familiar face, gives him a squeeze on the shoulder and walks off with his wife.

MRS. KELLER (CONT'D)
(Turning around) Oh Sam, Nora should be around here somewhere. You know, there isn't much time until she is off to college.

Samuel scans the room, anxious and eager. He spots NORA KELLER (18) just across the room and starts forward just to be blocked by the large looming frame of GRANDMA BEATRICE.

GRANDMA BEATRICE
“Oh Sammy! Look how tall you are, how are you?”

SAMUEL
(disappointed)
“Hi Grammy...”

GRANDMA BEATRICE
“I’ve heard a rumor that you won’t be off to college this fall dear, is everything alright?

SAMUEL
Yeah Grammy everything is fine, I should go I think my mom needs help with something.”

Samuel begins walking away but not before hearing his grandmother’s comment to his eavesdropping Aunt Carol.

GRANDMA BEATRICE
“Oh that boy, pray he doesn’t end up like Joe...”

Samuel, now over by the appetizer table, looks around for Nora. Across the room, a loud cacophony of laughter erupts, in the center Julia stands smiling up at her adoring fan club. Samuel scoffs, angrily eats a piece of cheese, and walks into the room hoping to find Nora somewhere in the crowd.

Walking in sight of his younger sister’s view, Julia and Samuel make eye contact. Julia gives him a smug smile.

JULIA
“Hey Auntie Marle, look it’s Sam I know you’ve been meaning to chat with him about, well, YOU know... (to the larger group) You know, Sammy has always been a great inspiration to me, I wouldn’t be where I am at today if I hadn’t had him as an example.”

The crowd, lead by Aunt Marlene head in Samuel’s direction. Before being swallowed up by the group of curious friends and family, Samuel can just make out the face of Julia, still smiling, settling into her chair.

Now surrounded, Samuel begins answering rapid fire questions, looking for a break in the crowd.

SAMUEL
“Mr. and Mrs. Corwin, its good to see you... no I am not sure what I want to do yet”

Samuel whips around to face Aunt Marlene.

AUNT MARLENE
“Oh Sammy! So good to see you, I’ve spoken quite a bit with your sister, you must be proud! School president and only 14! She tells me you’ve decided not to go to college. Is that because of the AI? Oh dear , I know things are looking bleak but you must persevere!

FAMILY FRIEND
“Oh you know you should talk to my husband Ted. He was just at a conference about AI in the workplace. I’ll give you his number.”

SAMUEL
“Oh um sure that would be great.”

Turning away, Samuel catches a glimpse of Nora watching the scene and Julia making her way over to her.

FAMILY FRIEND 2
“Forget college son! When I was your age, I walked right into COMPANY and made them give me a job.

SAMUEL
I’m not interested in sales.

FAMILY FRIEND 3
“Well then, how about sports? You look like you could be a tennis man! I hear your sister just won some championship in basketball.”

SAMUEL
“No I don’t play any sports”

AUNT MARLENE
(Looking around at the crowd)“Well then what do you do?”

The crowd laughs, an opening is created and Samuel takes the opportunity.

SAMUEL
“Excuse me, I need to use the restroom”

AUNT MARLENE
“Aw way to show decisiveness! Gosh teenagers!”

CUT TO:

INT. BATHROOM - NIGHT

Samuel locks the door and sighs. He douses his face with water and looks in the mirror.

SAMUEL
(To himself)
“They think they can judge me... Cousin Joyce didn’t even finish community college... I mean sales? You do they think I am?... They don’t get you..”

He looks at himself in the mirror, surprised by his vicious competitiveness. His moment of peace is cut short by a knock at the door. Opening it, Samuel is met with the person he had been looking for all night, Nora.

NORA
“Hey, tough crowd out there huh?”

SAMUEL
“Yeah, I mean what do you expect from a room full of people who think owning a Prius is a political statement.”

NORA
“(Laughs) Good one. But I mean they mean well...”

SAMUEL
“Ha sure... I saw your parents earlier, I might go to one of your Dad’s lectures.”

NORA
Oh... that's nice. I hope he didn't talk your head off, he can be socially unaware.

SAMUEL
"What? No not at all I've always liked your dad's little lectures... I hear your off to college."

NORA
"Yeah and I hear you're not. What happened Sam?

SAMUEL
"Nothing, something bad doesn't have to happen to not want to go to some glorified institution that teaches you how to talk about inequality over wine."

Nora and Samuel look at each other for a moment. Nora, clearly frustrated, starts walking away before changing her mind and turning around.

NORA
"You know Sam, a lot of people would kill to be in your shoes. I mean Jesus look at this party it must have cost a fortune. Look at your mom, she must own a bag from every designer brand out there. You just don't get it Sam."

Samuel watches her walk off with a shocked look on his face. He scoffs in disbelief of the conversation he just had. Hearing laughter coming from the other room, he shakes his head, smiles, and walks down the hall.

CUT TO:

INT. LIVING ROOM - EVENING

The party is in full swing, some talk and laugh, others munch on various small dishes while they watch whatever football game was put on the TV. Samuel scans the room, noticing a group of familiar faces and walks towards them with a dangerous confidence.

SAMUEL
“Mr. and Mrs. Adler! How ARE you? You know, your name has become quite popular around here.”

MR. ADLER
“Oh hello... I’m sorry young man I don’t believe we’ve met.”

SAMUEL
“Oh no we haven’t met, I’m Sam, Samuel Feldman. I believe you are working with my dad.”

MR. ADLER
“Aw yes, your father has been... quite persistent.”

SAMUEL
“Well what can you expect from a man whose being lowballed.”

MR. ADLER
“Ha funny, he’ll break at some point.”

SAMUEL
“Don’t say that, it’s my father’s biggest dream to be off somewhere like Bora Bora pretending to work — living the good life, like you seem to have mastered.

MR. ADLER
“I beg your pardon?”

The room quiets as heads turn to see Mrs. Feldman pulling Samuel into the hall.

MRS. FELDMAN
“SAMUEL! (Realizing her loud volume) Please excuse my son Mr. Adler, I am so sorry.

Mrs. Feldman leads Samuel into the quiet hall.

MRS. FELDMAN (CONT’D)
What are you doing? Why are you doing this?

SAMUEL
Mom I was just having fun. You told me to charm those money-hungry walking 401ks.

MRS. FELDMAN
Don’t you dare call them that. What has gotten into you? This whole not going to college thing, what is it, revenge? Trying to get back at me and your father for something?

SAMUEL
Mom...

MRS. FELDMAN
Sam, college or no college, things have a way of working out for a kid like you. Some things don’t change, no matter how far you go and you need to realize that. We will be there when you do.

Mrs. Feldman leaves, Samuel leans back on the wall alone in the hall. He drops his head, replaying the events of the night. Julia’s smug face, Nora’s disappointment, his mother’s biting words flash through his mind. He sees himself looking in that bathroom mirror, remembering the anger, competition, and enjoyment he felt in that moment. Hearing a noise he looks up to see Julia standing in front of him. She extends her hand, he takes it, and they walk back into the party together.